

2024

SeaVees Student Ambassadorship Proposal



UCSB American Marketing Association

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Introduction

SeaVees Ambassadorship Program Proposal

The following report outlines the proposed SeaVees Student Ambassadorship Program. Enlisting student brand ambassadors to create content will improve brand reputation and recognition, drive sales revenue, and solidify a loyal customer base.

According to Business Today, average company value is 16% higher for those referred to a product or brand by an influencer than an unREFERRED customer. Additionally, 70% of students take action—whether researching a brand or purchasing products—after interacting with college influencer and/or ambassador content

We propose that the ideal ambassador demographic would specifically be college students. By recruiting University of California, Santa Barbara (UCSB) students for this future program, student ambassadors will spread brand awareness on campus through both word-of-mouth and content creation. Local students will be motivated to apply and capitalize on professional opportunities by providing incentives and discounted or free access to merchandise.

Three potential ambassadorship models are outlined in this proposal, each designed to accomplish something slightly different from one another to promote program longevity and potential for replication across other college campuses: a) SeaVees “Seekers” will independently collaborate with UCSB organizations and sponsor online content as “self-starting” student ambassadors, b) the SeaVees “Sole Crew” would promote a community amongst a student content creation team, and c) “Thriftie” ambassadors will promote SeaVees’s alignment with the second-hand-shopping and/or sustainable subcultures of Santa Barbara.

Understanding the Target Audience

Seavees Ambassadorship Program is engineered for college students to promote SeaVees brand to a younger consuming audience, specifically other college students and young adults.

This demographic, encompassing the older segment of Gen-Z, is ideal for several reasons: students are in a transitional phase where brand loyalties are still forming. College is a time to find oneself, one's sense of style and a time to begin making own own purchasing decisions. These decisions are often influenced by trends observed first hand and recommendations from peers. We found in our AMA outreach survey that 65% of respondents discover new brands from word of mouth, and 90% of people share their reviews of products through direct conversations. By extension, college campuses are the ideal site for word of mouth communication due to their geographically concentrated student populations and daily interpersonal interactions.

Additionally, college students of this generation have a large presence on social media where they share their personal lives and draw inspiration from the content of their peers. A team of college age ambassadors would be ideal to promote the Seavees brand because they can gain the trust of others in their age group and get the product in the eye of the public just by walking around campus.



This peer-peer marketing approach fosters trust and reliability, making college students the perfect ambassadors and target audience for Seavees.

UC Santa Barbara (UCSB) students additionally present ideal target ambassadors and consumers for SeaVees, given the established second-hand shopping culture, beach-side adjacency, and sought-after reputation as some of the happiest students in California. The Downtown Santa Barbara SeaVees location's proximity to UCSB campus would further facilitate strong relationships and a sense of community between brand and ambassadors. Additionally, SeaVees' origin ties and persistent commitment to sustainability aligns perfectly with UCSB's environmentally conscious culture as the third ranked most eco-conscious campus in the nation.

Ambassadorship Model 1: “SeaVees Seekers”

Our first proposal–SeaVees “Seekers”–is oriented around the website statement “We are here for the seekers.”



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**We are here for the
Seekers.**

The ideal candidate for this position would be self-driven and eager to grow their personal brand on social media. Depending on the intended reach, this program would consist of 5-10 campus ambassadors who would create User Generated Content (UGC) on both Instagram and TikToks platforms. The ideal candidate would be a self-starting, motivated person who is involved in on-campus activities and would outreach to their personal connections on behalf of the brand.

Requirements and Training:

The requirements for the SeaVees Seekers Campus Ambassador role are that you must be 18 years or older, must be enrolled in a 4-year university, and must be in good academic standing. It is also highly encouraged to have an active social media presence, are passionate about sustainability and the SeaVees brand, and demonstrate a passion for content creation. The application process will involve an online application via the SeaVees website in which applicants will log in using their campus-provided emails.

Following the initial application, SeaVees will select candidates for a Zoom interview and will choose their ambassadors following that. In addition to being available on the SeaVees website, the application will also be sent via relevant department listservs on campus such as the Communication department for additional outreach opportunities.

Training for this program will consist of an initial team meeting at the Funk Zone location for Santa Barbara residents, allowing ambassadors to familiarize themselves with the brand and network with one another. Furthermore, there will be a required online module to introduce the brand values. Following the onboarding process, there will be quarterly check-ins for the duration of the one-year program to track individual progress, analyze KPIs, and remain current with new drops.

Content Creation and Incentives:

Ambassadors will be expected to post one TikTok and one Instagram post per month. In our survey on online shopping habits, 68% of participants indicated that they prefer engaging with brands that share behind-the-scenes content on social media. Therefore, as ambassadors of the brand, 'Seekers' are encouraged to visit the store often and post about visiting the store as well as about new campaigns. Other content ideas include day-in-the-life type videos especially with an active lifestyle, Instagram posts wearing the shoes, and review videos.



Along with the posts, ambassadors will receive a custom affiliate link to post with a discount code. For all purchases made through the link, SeaVees Seekers will receive a commission. In addition, ambassadors will have an additional personal discount code to be used for themselves only.

Measuring Progress:

To measure progress, SeaVees will designate one Campus Ambassador Program Coordinator to track posts and KPIs for each campus leader. The specific KPIs that will be analyzed include Social media traffic (impressions, likes, engagement rate, etc.), ambassador link website traffic, ambassador link click-through conversion rate (CTR). At quarterly check-ins, the Program Coordinator will discuss the KPIs with each ambassador and assess points of strength and areas for improvement.

Ambassadorship Model 2: SeaVees “Sole Crew”

Our second proposal–SeaVees “Sole Crew”–would be a teamwork-oriented and personality-based recruitment program.



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**Good soles for the
adventurous souls.**

Divergent from the previous Seekers program in its communal approach to content creation, the Sole Crew would be encouraged to collaborate with one another and discuss their content ideas, possibly taking on more responsibility in holding one another accountable. Together, 4-8 ambassadors would be able to promote an idealized image of community, minimalist luxury, and UCSB lifestyle. The additional strength of having a team-like structure of ambassadors is that the program has more of a network of reach and increased customer engagement.



Requirements and Training:

The first requirements to apply as a member of the “Sole Crew” would include that the potential ambassadors are at least 18 years old and enrolled as college students. The students must be involved on campus and in good academic standing, as well as active on a public social media account. The unique aspect of this particular program is that the recruitment process would require the student to send in videos of themselves along with answering application questions, either answering prompted questions, creative responses, or merely showing their personality—this would help screen for a diverse group that also compliments one another well, spreading across multiple target areas of UCSB campus. This program would rely on **personality hires** who could bring attention to SeaVees in the Isla Vista community and also on social media to other students on distant campuses. Incentives to join this program uniquely could involve private ambassador team events, such as photo shoots, behind-the-scenes access to marketing campaigns, sponsored trips to local spots for content creation, and/or catered meetups. Additionally, free products, commission from discount codes, and networking opportunities would motivate students to grow their personal brand by representing SeaVees.

Content Creation and Incentives:

Ambassadors would be encouraged to base their content around the team as a whole in addition to having the option to make individual content.

Some content ideas include Day in the Life vlogs/TikTok showcasing more of their everyday lives and personalities. More specifically, an ambassador can show their typical day at UCSB, showing their personality through the video while showcasing their SeaVees product(s). Ambassadors may also make content revolving around their favorite product styles, which would include SeaVees. More team-based content ideas can revolve around events put on by the “Sole Crew” that entice friendly competitions, sponsored by SeaVees. For example, the crew can host a spike ball tournament in which the winners win a free pair of SeaVees shoes. This would pique interest in the brand and have students come together for a product.

25% of AMA survey respondents reported that “community involvement by a brand significantly boosts its authenticity in their eyes.” Having a team-based ambassador program would not only be a model of community efforts, but it would also be able to encompass the wider community of Santa Barbara together through their mission. Onboarded training would include bonding with other ambassadors to form a collaborative and open team. They must be able to attend in-person group events to get content and interact. Ambassadors also have the ability to answer any questions or comments through SeaVees social media and personal platforms.

Measuring Progress:

A range of specific KPIs would be monitored such as online metrics (likes, follower growth, and interactions), event turnouts, and group evaluations through peer review and one-on-one meetings for debriefs and reflections. The “Sole Crew” would also be encouraged to share what content has been more successful on their accounts to brainstorm how to boost the ambassadorship’s overall visibility.

We will be able to monitor the heightened visibility of SeaVees amongst the UCSB student population and also witness the effectiveness of working in a team environment.

Ambassadorship Model 3: “UCSB Thriftees”

Our third proposed ambassadorship would recruit student representatives to become SeaVees content creators known as “Thriftees.”



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**Nifty and Thriftee?
Join our Team.**

This program specifically targets the UCSB students who are thrift-obsessed, as these students are oftentimes fashion-forward, uniquely style themselves, and are well motivated to help others find discounts for clothing.

“Thriftees” similarly mimics the spelling of SeaVees and is a call-back to the brand’s origin story of a second chance after its re-discovery at a thrift store. While the degree of sustainability-centricity can be tailored to align with the desired level of the brand overall, the thrift scene at UCSB presents a large untapped market of students that may be inclined to either represent or patronize SeaVees.

Sustainability Insight:

47% of respondents in the AMA outreach survey indicated that they have purchased a product because of its commitment to social causes, many specifically citing Patagonia for its sustainable commitments. By recruiting student influencers who are sustainably-minded, either in their second-hand shopping practices or by personal values, a larger consumer loyalty can be reached as well as cultivated amongst other thrift-minded individuals. Several respondents cited how they stopped patronizing a brand due to their lack of sustainable ethics (ex. non-vegan makeup brands). 56% of respondents either strongly or slightly agreed that sustainability is as important when choosing footwear to comfort and style.

Requirements:

Similarly screening potential Thriftees to be over 18 years old and a student in good academic standing at a four-year institution, a unique feature of this screening process could be to submit some sample outfit pictures to have diverse style amongst SeaVees student reps. Additionally, students can submit on an application portal a sample of their social media feed to better assess their online aesthetic to determine if they could seamlessly highlight SeaVees products. The application may also include general short answer questions like "Why do you want to be a SeaVees student ambassador?" and "What are you involved in on campus?" Finally, a unique aspect of the Thriftee program is to recruit student ambassadors separately for either Tik Tok OR Instagram—this two-pronged approach to social media could help when weighing applicants to prioritize recruiting already established students on Tik Tok or Instagram, as the content for each app varies greatly and could help ease the generation of content for ambassadors and the managerial end.

We could advertise this on the application as becoming a part of **"Thrifteetok" or "Thirfteegram,"** which overall helps consolidate content on either platforms and ensures a higher quality of content production.

Content Creation and Incentives:

Incentives to Thriftee ambassadors could include personal discounts, free merchandise to shoot content with, and special merchandise to signify their membership (ex. "Think Thriftee" tote bags) as well as promote the ambassadorship to other prospective students.



As for professional development, we could emphasize the ability to grow the student's personal social media brand as well as the opportunity to develop business communication skills. Aligning with SeaVees' support of sustainable causes, a portion of the commission from the influencer's codes could go towards this effort.

Some content ideas for Tik Tok include interviewing UCSB students by the library about what they are wearing and/or if anything is thrifted, ending with the ambassador showcasing their SeaVees shoes; Thriftees could also film themselves after a thrift haul or shopping at the second hand pop-ups to build outfits around their SeaVees sneakers; ambassadors could further play into the eco-conscious scene at UCSB by filming at fun eco-club events (ex. Surfrider, Gauchos Go Green), who often have fundraisers, Isla Vista band concerts, and collaborations with student life orgs.; photos on Instagram would capitalize on the natural atmospheres of Santa Barbara and SeaVees footwear.

Training:

The ambassador training would involve signing a code of conduct to ensure influencers will engage in appropriate online behavior while serving as a Thirftree ambassador. Additionally, various brands with ambassadorship programs have online modules to train their influencers.

An onboarding session with SeaVees social media team could inform the ambassadors of how to upkeep a content calendar, stipulate their expected weekly productions of content, and discuss how often they will receive new merchandise to promote.

Measuring Performance:

Performance can be monitored through remote individual check-ins over the month to discuss what the ambassador thinks is going well and what is not. The ambassador will also be responsible for reporting UCSB organizations they are collaborating with and pursuing new outlets for content.

Specific KPIS would include monitoring website traffic, social media growth, and click-through rates of online content. We could specifically monitor the progression of SeaVees visibility and website traffic throughout the ambassadorship calendar to gauge the scale of success.

Strategic Implementation

To ensure the success of the SeaVees Student Ambassadorship Program, it is fundamental to implement the best practices in recruiting, training, and retaining ambassadors.

This section outlines how to achieve such practices, supported by AMA survey outreach results and a comparison of different popular ambassador programs.

Recruiting ambassadors involves targeted outreach, creative application processes, and clear incentives. Leveraging platforms like Instagram and TikTok is essential, as 65% of students discover new brands through word of mouth, and 90% share their experiences through direct conversations or social media, according to our AMA survey. Utilizing these platforms allows SeaVees to reach potential ambassadors effectively and increase brand awareness. Therefore, selected applications should be students who appear engaging, personable, and interactive. The potential for a video submission and social media samples outlined in some of the campaigns could help assess candidates' creativity and engagement in this way. Initial in-person events or virtual meetings can foster a sense of community from the outset, aligning with the approach used in the SeaVees "Seekers" and student "Sole Crew" programs.

Training ambassadors effectively requires comprehensive onboarding and ongoing support. Structured onboarding programs should include training modules on brand values, social media best practices, and content creation guidelines. Research indicates that a significant majority of SeaVees consumers value the brand's social and environmental commitments, as shown in the survey where 73% of respondents said these commitments influenced their purchase decisions. Utilizing task management tools can further streamline this process by organizing training materials and tracking ambassador progress.

Ambassadors should sign a code of conduct to ensure consistent brand representation. Regular check-ins, workshops focused on content creation, and resources such as content calendars and creative briefs can help ambassadors stay aligned with SeaVees' goals and expectations. The SeaVees “Seekers” and “Thrifties” programs emphasize the importance of ongoing training and support to maintain high-quality content and engagement.

Retaining ambassadors involves recognizing and rewarding top performers, offering professional development opportunities, and building a supportive community. Regular recognition through social media shout-outs, exclusive merchandise, and additional incentives can motivate ambassadors. A tiered rewards system, based on performance metrics such as social media engagement rates and website traffic driven by ambassadors, can further encourage sustained participation. Professional development opportunities, such as networking events and skill-building workshops, appeal to ambitious students looking to enhance their resumes. Fostering a sense of community through regular group activities and mentorship programs helps retain ambassadors by creating a supportive and collaborative environment.

Ultimately, the success of the SeaVees Student Ambassadorship Program hinges on selecting ambassadors who align with the brand's values and who demonstrate strong communication skills and a solid work ethic. Providing ambassadors with the necessary tools and support to succeed is crucial. SeaVees should ensure that ambassadors find their roles fulfilling and experience continuous professional growth. By fostering an environment where ambassadors feel empowered and challenged, SeaVees can build a loyal and motivated ambassador team that effectively promotes the brand and its values, ultimately driving increased sales and long-term growth for the company. The success of this program at UCSB will further convey how to successfully replicate ambassadorships at other college campuses.

Performance Measurement

Different KPI measurements will be used to evaluate the effectiveness of marketing of different platforms.

Website Trafficking	Social Media Traffic	Click-Through Rates
Website Trafficking assesses the effectiveness of ambassador activities on driving website traffic.	Social Media Traffic can be used to measure the growth in followers, engagement rates (likes, comments, shares), and the volume of traffic redirected from social media platforms to SeaVees website.	Click-through rates help measure effectiveness of ambassador-generated content by clicking on links to SeaVees website.
Tracking parameters can be added to URLs shared on their social media accounts to help track which ambassadors are driving the most traffic.	Social media like Instagram have their own platforms of providing insightful KPI measurements, which can evaluate which ambassadors are most effective at attracting the audience and increasing brand visibility.	With evaluation of different ambassadors, we can evaluate who's marketing and specific content of the creation to continue with. Embedded links can be used to record clicks.
This measurement would be useful for the Seekers ambassadorship prototype, as it would be easier to track which student ambassadors are ushering in more direct traffic from their personal social media links.	This could be measured on the SeaVees social media as well as the brand ambassador social accounts, lending itself to the Sole Crew design's ambassador content team.	This metric is beneficial as it correlates to potential sales conversion and overall impact of the ambassadors' marketing abilities.

The ambassador program first needs to find the right students to be able to access the true hubs of student life at UCSB. Each UCSB department regularly emails internships and professional development opportunities to the corresponding students in their department. The UCSB Communications department would be an ideal outreach point for SeaVees, as many of the opportunities emailed to students are related to brand promotion, social media, and other revenues of communication. Reaching out to be promoted by the UCSB Writing Department also would be ideal, as many of the writing minor students get involved in courses about public relations, brand development, copywriting, social media, and multimedia.

Marketing and Promotion

Each Panhellenic fraternity or sorority is consistently corresponding with brands or local businesses to sponsor their Fall recruitment. Most sororities get sponsors (ex. Celsius, Yerba Maté, Princess Polly, etc.) to create content during Polish Week, which is the week-two weeks before primary recruitment cycles begin. This year, Polish Weeks will be at the beginning of September, from September 9th, 2024 to September 24th, 2024. It would be ideal to reach out to Panhellenic social media teams by the independent sorority just before these dates to organize a potential collaboration for recruitment—the Greek organizations are accessible via Instagram, direct message or by emailing their recruitment directors. By collaborating to highlight SeaVees shoes for recruitment, there is a potential to access a large pool of potential ambassador applicants to recruit just before the start of the school year.

Additionally, UCSB has a Career Fair every quarter, so SeaVees or other ambassadors could possibly have a booth to recruit students who are looking to find more social-media related opportunities available to them in the local area. A popular means of advertisement among the student body also is called “tabling” in the Arbor, which is a student quad right in front of the UCSB library. There are tables and booths of student organizations and professional clubs advertising themselves to people who walk by, so having some ambassadors and/or student reps. interacting with people at a table with a few pairs of showcased SeaVees shoes would likely get a lot of interest.

Reaching interested UCSB students on follow-heavy UCSB Instagram accounts is a good way to target social-media savvy students. SeaVees social media additionally can post to advertise the ambassadorship, using hashtags that would tie it into UCSB-related content.

[UCSB Communication Department](mailto:comminfo@comm.ucsb.edu) - comminfo@comm.ucsb.edu

[UCSB Writing Department](mailto:wpinfo@writing.ucsb.edu) - wpinfo@writing.ucsb.edu

[Panhellenic Sorority Outreach](mailto:leiladonner@ucsb.edu) - leiladonner@ucsb.edu (Kappa Alpha Theta)

[Panhellenic Fraternity Outreach](#) -

[Gauchos Go Green](mailto:miraobecker@gmail.com) - miraobecker@gmail.com

[UCSB Career Fair](mailto:careerevents@sa.ucsb.edu) - careerevents@sa.ucsb.edu

Future Growth and Adaptation

The student ambassadorship program can grow to maintain its relevance and effectiveness primarily by focusing on integrating research and training to ensure that the program and its ambassadors are well-versed in the current platforms and trends, as well as creating a purposeful community that incentivizes ambassadors to continue collaboration and production.

01

Staying on trend

For the ambassadors to engage an audience that ultimately attracts customers, their posts need to be on point with those popular trends to be seen by strangers on social media. This important piece to the ambassadorship requires research into those posts: this research could consist of tracking posts on platforms like TikTok and Instagram, to see what trend is currently going around. This could also consist of surveying each ambassador's knowledge of the current trends or forecasted content outline, since they are most likely active on these social media platforms outside the ambassadorship, they most likely have various insights on the trends on that date.

02

Carving out a community

To maintain its effectiveness, the ambassadorship program additionally should foster a community within the program to support its members and allow for a growing number of participants, as well as successfully integrate and penetrate into UCSB student culture. Ambassador community can be done by the incentives that are offered in the program, but also perhaps in networking events where the ambassadors can create meaningful relationships with their peers, as well as full time workers at SeeVees.

03

Aiming to expand to more universities

As many college students are looking to further their experience in social media/business fields, the program could advertise helping these potential future ambassadors with personalized goals and tiers of flexible participation. The ambassadorship program should thus diversify and expand its reach to other campuses. With college students from around the country contributing to spreading SeeVees' message and brand, its sustainability ideals and products can be more effectively shared. The UCSB ambassadors could also serve as means in researching how to make the program more collaborative.

04

Preserving brand values

Recruiting ambassadors that work well in the system and support SeeVees vision is thus integral to the success of ambassadorship, so by recruiting new ambassadors on a rolling cycle, the program can sustain its goals more efficiently as qualified people sign up with their new ideas as new trends in the social media world emerge. The current ambassadors could also provide insight and feedback for how to better recruit members, as well as be a resource for giving solid recommendations for people for the program who they know are interested.

Conclusion

By implementing a student ambassador program, SeaVees will increase brand recognition and sales while building customer loyalty on college campuses.

AMA survey results indicate that 65% of students discover new brands through peer recommendations, and 90% share product reviews through direct conversations, highlighting their potential for impactful word-of-mouth marketing. UCSB college students employed as brand ambassadors will help to establish SeaVees' local presence, and can serve as a basis for expansion to other colleges. We propose three models—SeaVees "Seekers," "Sole Crew," and "Thirftees"—each designed to engage different student segments and promote the brand through content creation, teamwork, and sustainable fashion initiatives.

To implement the SeaVees Student Ambassadorship Program effectively, recruitment should leverage social media platforms and have creative application processes and clear incentives. We would recommend allowing ample time for the first application period (June-September) to recruit ambassadors, who could start in September when Fall quarter for UCSB courses will start. When advertising the ambassador opportunities, SeaVees should reach out to the UCSB Communication Department, reaching out to Panhellenic groups, and other student organizations to seek applicants. Training should include onboarding, support, and provide modules on brand values and social media standards.

SeaVees should recognize top performers by offering professional development opportunities, hosting private events and/or giving merchandise, as well as aiming to foster a supportive, loyal community.

Marketing strategies should include targeted outreach and engaging promotional campaigns. Continuous evolution of the program can be achieved through integrating current trends, continuous recruiting of new faces throughout the school year, and implementing opportunities for student feedback. Eventually, if successful in promoting products and brand values at UCSB, SeaVees can implement the project on other campuses.



SeaVees Seekers

- Speaking to the self-starting students to promote brand on social media

SeaVees Sole Crew

- Team-oriented ambassador team to tackle UCSB student body



Thirftees

- Staying true to brand origin story and sustainable values by recruiting fashionable second-hand shoppers

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UCSB AMA thanks you for the opportunity to envision SeaVees' student ambassadorship program.

Nicole Kennedy
AMA Team Captain
nicolekennedy@ucsb.edu
(925) 330-1364

Contact

<https://www.ucsbama.com>